of getting easier to bat on rather than harder, so batting last might not be the worst thing in the world for Australia. The score is 22-2. Michael Clarke, the captain, is batting. He is the talisman for the team, by far their most in-form player, undeniably world-class, and we have targeted him as the big wicket to take. We have had tussles ever since he played in the Lancashire League against me and our trajectories have aligned, only coming across each other now for these big moments. Both of us are uber-competitive and in each other's presence, a hyper-motivation floods both of us.

The ball is not swinging much so I am having to use different skills. I am no longer the bowler who runs in and hopes the ball will do the other-worldly – hooping late, turning batters inside out into twisted S shapes. It is more of a process now, more microscopic. Things do not come without my conception, but now everything is planned, fine-tuned, evolved, deadly intentional. I have been using a new delivery for me, the wobble seam. Bowling this, my fingers grip the ball a little looser and you hope the seam will scatter slightly in the air, rather than travel gun-barrel straight. I know the pitch is dry and the conditions unhelpful, so it requires moulding, wickets a puzzle to be pieced together based on experience, information and instinct.

As it leaves my fingers, it feels exactly as I want it to. There is a millisecond where, as my head dives down and the ball leaves my hand, I think to myself that it might nip away. The line and length is spot on, I already know that. Clarke offers to block the ball and, just as it had suggested to me on leaving my hand, it moves a fraction away from him. The absolute ideal fraction, not too little and not too much. There is a sound – so slight and acute – that I think it must be an outside edge to the wicketkeeper. As I see the slip cordon running off and Clarke tucking his bat under his arm to walk off, I notice as I run past that a bail has been dislodged. That sound was the stumps, not his bat. I've bowled him. Hearing the crowd all celebrating, pints thrown into the air and bodies falling over each other in joy, I point both hands at the stumps as I run past, in adrenalised shock.

It's my favourite ball – maybe because it isn't one that initially came naturally to me, as if it was handed to my system. Instead, it's something I had to work on, building it up over hours and hours of practice, working out how to move the ball when it wasn't swinging dramatically and when I